- *Trust enabler* --In a decentralized system of participants, there are no central authorities or intermediaries such as banks. You, therefore, need an infrastructure that implements the rules for governance, provenance, compliance, and the like automatically, without any intermediaries. Blockchain software assumes the role of a *trust enabler* (section 1.3.4).

1.3.1 Decentralized infrastructure

Blockchain infrastructure is inherently decentralized, like the railway tracks or roadways connecting cities. You can think of the Dapps that you'll deploy as being like the trains or vehicles that travel on the tracks and roads. With this picture in your mind, let's explore that infrastructure. I'll defer the technical details and coding of the applications to later chapters. Your aim in this chapter is to comprehend the crucial role played by blockchain infrastructure in supporting decentralized systems.

What is a decentralized system? A *decentralized* system is a type of distributed system in which

- Participants communicate peer to peer.
- Participants are in control of their assets, digital or otherwise (such as an audio file, a digital health record, or a piece of land).
- Participants can join and leave the system as they wish.
- Participants operate beyond the typical boundaries of trust (such as within a university or a country).